the manger’. The Hindus, noted the Jesuits, were rather more inclined than the Muslims to join in these pastoral and mystical celebrations. But there was one exalted visitor whom the Jesuits were delighted to find was very curious about these celebrations. The Prince Salim, they wrote, ‘publicly expressed his devotion to our Lord and our Lady, and placed their pictures, on which he delighted to gaze, in his own chamber’. They further noted that ‘whenever the Portuguese, or other Christians at the court, obtained good copies of such pictures from India or Portugal, they used to present them to the Prince, knowing that this would greatly please him’. When the Jesuit mission had arrived at Lahore in 1595, Salim had been ‘very angry with those who had conducted the Fathers, because they had not brought him any picture of our Lady from Goa’. The Jesuits had, however, brought a Portuguese painter along and Salim immediately commanded him to make a copy of the painting the Jesuits owned of the Virgin Mary. When Salim then visited the Jesuits’ chapel he saw an embossed image of the baby Jesus and one of a crucifix and ordered similar ones ‘to be made for himself in ivory by his own craftsmen’.

Desperate to find a convert in the Mughal family, the Jesuits failed to see that it was not so much their religion that enticed Salim, but their art. It was perhaps only when surrounded by the painters in the taswir khanas and among the gilded and glowing paintings that Salim felt himself to be the equal of his illustrious father. For Salim had an impeccable eye for beauty and his own studios, when he had become Padshah Jahangir, would create intricate worlds of immaculate precision and beauty. Salim would use the influence of the very works of art he was gleaning from the Jesuits and through them, the wider European art world, to enhance the work produced in his ateliers. And yet precisely at this time, contrary to the direction his own studios would take in the following decade, Salim began to sponsor a capriciously different style of painting.

Kavita Singh has pointed out that the paintings sponsored by Salim at this time from the late 1590s until the time he became emperor in 1605, ‘harked back to Safavid painting of the mid-century and were in a style that had long been out of fashion in Akbar’s atelier’. Akbar’s artists, as has been seen, now expertly fused Hindustani effervescence and virility with rounded European forms and Persian restraint. But Salim began patronizing a new group of artists—recent immigrants to Lahore from Persia. These men included Muhammad Riza, Mirza Ghulam, and Salim Quli but the most